

The term Phishing was coined in the mid 1990s by crackers who attempted to steal account details from AOL. The modus operandi would be very simple: an attacker would pose as an AOL staffer and send an IM to a potential victim asking him to give out his password to verify his account or confirm his billing. Once the password was given away the attacker could access the victim's account and use it for criminal purposes, such as spamming.

Now, if Phishing is actually fishing for a victim, why is it spelt with a "Ph"? Hackers and crackers are very nostalgic people. The term is a take on the original form of hacking called 'phone phreaking'. Now 'Ph' has become a common hacker replacement for 'f'.

Phishing has now become one of the major threats on the Internet today because of the rise in financial transactions being conducted online. A number of companies have filed cases against these unknown attackers claiming millions in damages.

It's not all bleak, though. There are a few anti-phishing software available. These programs are often integrated with Web browsers and e-mail clients as a toolbar that displays the real domain name for the visiting Web site. This prevents the most common form of phishing attack called spoofing.

Another variant of this form of fraudulent attack is Pharming, where, instead of setting up a similar Web site for spoofing, the DNS server software is exploited and the hacker acquires the domain name of a site and redirects traffic from that site to another Web site. This site is then used to steal or "phish" a visitor's account details, or even the payment information. However, such an attack is only possible if the site is not SSL (Security Socket Layer) protected. To be on the safer side, it is advisable not to ignore the security certificate warnings attached with a Web site.

Many experts feel that Pharming is far more potent as compared to Phishing, since, in Pharming, the criminals can get many